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George Winkler discovered Jordon River mine with a pickaxe and a backpack

George Winkler sits among memories of a rugged outdoor life in his Government Street office. - Barry Casson photo.

by
Patty Pitts

"In the old days", said the 98-year-old prospector, "you looked at your country and tried to find an outcropping. Then you put a pack on your back and went out with a partner with pack horses. Today, they send an airplace over it."

George Winkler has lived long enough to see both ways. Although he fully accepts the present modern methods, it's obvious his heart is in the old way, when man fought nature for the right to achieve instant success and wealth by mining her minerals.

Winkler, who discovered Sunro mine in Jordan River staked his claim the tougher way back in 1915 while he was working at her camps. His search began in 1909 when a friend got him a job running a commissary for the workers installing a hydro-electric plant at Jordan River.

"A man I met in the Okanagan gave me the job but I waited for some time before hearing from him," remembers Winkler, "so I jumped on a tug that went around Race Rocks and arrived at the camp. I told them I'm worth my grub, anyway until you get the commissary opened!"

Winkler spent that winter living in tents in Jordan River using his spare afternoons to take walks along the beach taking his prospect pick with him. During one outing he picked up some low grade material, which Winkler felt had come downstream with indications of copper.

However, that summer the urge to see more of the country drove him to the Queen Charlottes where he did some work but found no riches. In the fall he returned to his old job in Jordan River. After wintering two more years in the camp, the thought of the low grade material he had found

George Winkler
- Barry Casson photo.

started him looking once again.

When he made a positive find that molybdenite was available, he decided to go after the copper. In 1915 he found an outcrop under the Forebay reservoir, named it Sunlock and staked six claims on it. Later on that same year he staked his claims on Gabbro mine, some 600 acres adjoining the Sunlock group, naming them after the rock responsible for the mineralization. Winkler and his partner then thought about selling to an ex-Cominco man named Stewart and his partner from Rossland. Referring to Stewart's partner, Winkler says "I didn't hit it off well at all. He was one of those damned book men." However, his own partner kept in touch with the Rossland men and Winkler finally sold him his option for $35,000.

Stewart then started rounding up a syndicate to explore the property who were mostly from CPR and Cominco - who responded by buying up enough volume to oust Stewart completely. For two years he ended teamed up with his former competitor George Winkler.

Meanwhile Cominco had their eyes on Gabbro. "They wanted it," said Winkler, "but they didn't want to pay for it. They had an option when they took over Sunlock but didn't take it."

Winkler sunk $27,000 into Gabbro and got in touch with Noranda offering them the option to drill on the basis of 10 cents a share for 600,000 treasury shares. When Noranda became interested, Cominco wanted to stop the transaction but Winkler ignored them. Finally, about 1950, drilling resulted in the discovery of an ore body that Noranda was reluctant to build a large tunnel for. Cominco then moved in and the two companies amalgumated, naming the two mines Sunro.

In 1960 Winkler was given, in addition to the numerous other shares he held, 20,000 more in lieu of a pension.

During the years he was the attraction of two of Canada's most powerful mining companies, he kept busy doing what he did best, examining the prospects of other people. He went on scouting trips, sometimes as far away as Valdez, Alaska, helping others searching for the elusive claim that would make them wealthy.

Now, close to a century old, George Winkler has to walk with a cane and has trouble with his hearing and sight but his mind is as quick as it was when he was juggling claims, owners and powerful companies. The office Winkler occupies above Spencer's on Government Street looks like it has been ignored by time since the turn of the century.

An ancient bookcase is loaded with piles of papers tied with string. Aerial photographs of the Jordan River area hang on the walls and chunks of copper ore take the place of knick-knacks on the table-top. Winkler likes to come here every day, even though the stairs are a challenge to him now, because his office is central and he can sit and chat with friends, remembering old times.

Born in Kincardine, Ontario in 1875 his family moved to rugged Manitoulin Island when he was just a youngster. The Woodward's, who later established the successful chain of stores in B.C. were the Winklers' neighbours.

Later, Winkler travelled to Manitoba, landing in B.C. in 1897 as joint manager of a store in Armstrong. He returned to Winnipeg for a brief stint on the Tribune but found his heart was in the mountains of the west. In 1900 he went to Greenwood, then just at its peak. "They were finishing the railway just nine miles beyond", recalls Winkler, "and there were 3,000 men working in that town with 22 saloons."

When Greenwood declined, he worked at Nickel Lake and took a swing through the Okanagan where he ran the Similkameen Star for two years, and continued the prospecting he had learned in Armstrong before he came out to Jordan River.

Throughout his rugged career as a prospector, Winkler has also indulged in the quiet art of poetry. His subjects are those he knows best -- the often solitary life of an outdoorsman, the animals who share the backland he prospects the lifestyle of a dying breed of man.

His work is good. Winkler's poems have been included in textbooks and literary anthologies for secondary schools along with illustrious poets like Robert Service and in the B.C. Centennial Anthology published in 1958.

Now George Winkler is content to visit with friends in his little office. He never married and the only surviving family he has is a brother in Vancouver and a sister in North Battleford, both of whom are younger. "I'm setting a record for the family", the 98-year-old said. His father died at 93.

"I haven't got the energy to get out as much as before", he explained, "I keep this office because it's a convenient place to meet. However, I'm interested in the Portland Canal area," he said, the familiar gleam returning to the eyes that have scouted so much land, "I'm trying to get something going there..." ●

Victoria Library survey underway

Residents of Greater Victoria who wish they could make it to the public library may soon find the library coming to them.

First contacts will be designed to produce information on needs through a community-wide survey. The survey is being prepared under the Local Initiatives Program, with federal support of $10,000.

Findings, to be presented by the middle of June, will help to guide the library in improving and extending service.

"We know of many individuals who want to use our resources, but who find access difficult or impossible at the moment," said *Donald Miller*, director of the Greater Victoria Public Library and sponsor of the LIP project.

"Some of them, for example, have physical handicaps that keep them at home or in hospital, or prevent them from reading.

"Others are housebound by family duties, with economic problems or special needs that the library could help to meet.

"But how many people are we talking about, and what services would give the most useful support to certain groups? Right now, we just don't know.

"We hope to identify the groups, and to work out the best way of providing services for them. Such ways might include adding more material in spoken form where print does not fill the purpose, and increasing the number of programs that we carry out in cooperation with other agencies."

Three field workers will

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